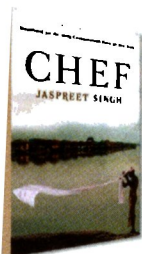


Taste for PEACE

A first novel uses the metaphor of cooking for reversing the ravages of war in Kashmir



CHEF
by JASPREET SINGH
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By Brinda Bose

So there is a Hindu Rogan Josh and a Muslim Rogan Josh. Over the years I have developed my own recipe, a Rogan Josh inspired by these two great traditions. I have perfected the dish, and I can say without hesitation that it is my finest accomplishment." Between two preparations of Rogan Josh (Hindu and Muslim) lies Kashmir.

Jaspreet Singh's first novel, *Chef*, is a lyrical, literary exercise in capturing the lingering essence of lost peace in disturbed, disputed territory. It is a novel intricately woven through a complex metaphor of cooking, that activity which produces food to sustain life in a world of grim soldiering which wields weapons to destroy it. In doing so, it pits food against death, and makes a serious, poignant plea for restoring peace in the Valley. Sensitively, beautifully written as it is, one wonders, though, whether its residual elegiac tone gestures toward the impossibility of its very premise.

Chef swings between two histories and two characters: its self-effacing narrator Kirpal ('Kip') whose gradual loss of (Sikh) identity and sense of self-worth is framed against his mentor and friend army Chef Kishen's far more dynamic life. Kirpal has grown up and into a passive role, under the shadow of his distinguished though dead war-

hero father. Chef Kishen, in contrast, impulsively and compulsively takes actions in his life that have significant and sometimes self-destructing consequences: he is consigned to the icy wastelands of the Siachen glacier for insulting a Muslim officer, and he stages his own incineration as some sort of an ecological protest. The connection between Kishen and Kirpal is through their chef-dom, for Kirpal succeeds Kishen in his job as army chef, but their relationship is far more complex and vital. On Kishen's part, at least, there is surely a deep sexual desiring and yearning for Kip that remains unfulfilled, and the journal that he leaves for the younger man is not merely to sustain a continuity of tradition in a strife-torn region by passing on recipes—but through this legacy, an attempt to bridge the yawning chasm between men who otherwise remain "strangers to one another".

The novel works at multiple metaphorical levels, all playing with, and into, each other. It is framed as a journey, undertaken by Kirpal to seek peace and understanding in conjoining past and present. The Partition of 1947 casts a long sombre shadow over the region that Singh traverses in and through parallel lives, and he captures in *Chef* the humming tensions of Kashmir with deft sensitivity and understated poignancy. The premise of the novel may seem an unlikely simplification of one of the subcontinent's most devastated lands, but strangely enough Singh is able to make it work with a certain panache, much as if he was wielding the famed light hand of a consummate pastry chef: that food is intricately linked to memory, and in remembering our most precious tastes of the past we may still find salvation where there seems to be only annihilation—and that love, that tenuous, incomprehensible, intangible emotion that sustains us and surprises us into life again and again is intricately, intimately, linked to food.

The language of food—from the delicacy of saffron to the pungency of hot, red Kashmiri chillies—obviously suggest that potent weapons for reversing the ravages of war and hatred need to be sought in unlikely places like the kitchen. The hybrid Muslim/Hindu Rogan Josh, that signature dish of the region, is Singh's ultimate plea for (re)conciliation, and the recipe for it is tantalisingly provided, for us to cook up a storm—in order, clearly, to assuage another. ■

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